

"Your enthusiasm is highly contagious!" That is what director Shane Black wrote in an e-mail to me when he wrote me to let me know I had landed the job of Production Designer on *Iron Man 3*. Yes, enthusiasm is something I have in abundance, and exactly what I would need and call upon in the ensuing months as we tackled the third installment of the revered *Iron Man* Series.

Immediately upon starting, I realized how vested Marvel Studios is in their characters and how much they care about the look of their films. Good ideas were welcomed, and nothing seemed to be off-limits as long as it supported the central characters. In order to meet the expectations, I put together a great team headed by Desma Murphy the Supervising Art Director and my Set Decorator Danielle Berman, both longtime collaborators.

Working on a film for Marvel was unlike any previous experience I had had. Each week, we held a design review where all visual design work was presented—from the suit and character design to the locations and scenery that were up for approval. Egos were checked at the door, and nothing was off-limits in our discussions. We sat in a small room—with the director, Marvel executives, and the design teams—and hashed out the look of the movie. It was helpful for me to hear from the other artists on the project, and hear their reactions to my work in an honest and straightforward way. This level of collaboration proved essential to achieving the overall look, and figuring out the visual and digital aspects of the movie. My goal on the movie was to create Tony Stark's world in the most realistic way possible and seamlessly blend in with the visual look of the last two *Iron Man* movies.

My journey of production-designing *Iron Man 3* was not unlike Tony Stark's journey to solve the riddle of the Mandarin and put his life back together after everything is taken from him. Like Tony, we eventually pulled out of our Los Angeles-based work reality and flew across country to the East Coast from Hollywood. Landing in Wilmington, North Carolina, we took over the entire Screen Gems Studios lot. North Carolina would now be our home for the next year and base of operations that had proximity to Miami, Florida, where we also had locations. Wilmington turned out to be a great town and a wonderful place where we all enjoyed working. But when we first arrived, we were out of our comfort zone and had to rediscover how to make a large action movie with the assets they had available.

After having designed the first two *Hangover* movies, I seemed to have gained a reputation as the person you go to when you want to create something that is beautifully designed then ultimately destroyed beyond recognition. One of the many tasks I was given was to destroy Tony Stark's amazing Malibu hilltop mansion and garage workshop! That is easy to say, but knocking a house of that size off a hill into the ocean was challenging. It required the talents of Academy Award-nominated special-effects wizard Dan Sudick. To achieve this, we built a huge hydraulic teeter-totter that could drop the entire house up and down at will. After that, we destroyed a small town, a Hollywood theater, Miami mansions, biotech labs, Air Force One, entire shipping docks, and so on.

De-constructivism was our general design theme and architectural style. We were constantly breaking all the elements of Tony's world down to their smallest parts—not unlike his suit, which was able to break apart into its small components then reconnect to his body. We pulled Tony out of his comfort zone and put him in that fish-out-of-water scenario. The more detail you put into this effort, the more it pays off visually. In our modern age of audiences, we have become so aware of real chaos and destruction that there is no cheating the looks of these kinds of events in the movies anymore. They expect to see realistic-looking destruction on-screen.

So in the book that precedes these words, you see what great collaboration is all about—all the creative departments that are needed to make an action movie in any place in the world working together with one focus on one character: Tony Stark.



Bill Brzeski